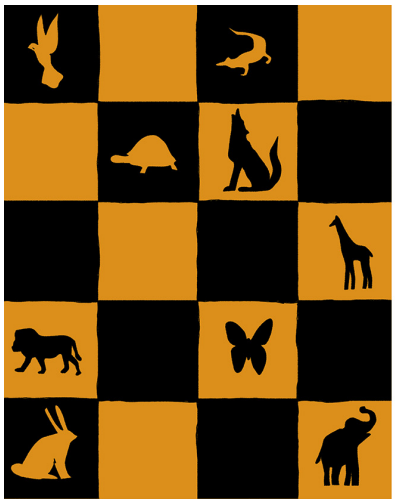


THE BEST STRATEGY DEPENDS ON WHAT OTHERS ARE DOING

EVOLUTIONARILY STABLE STATE

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

John Maynard Smith (1920–2004)

BEFORE

1944 Mathematician John von Neumann and economist Oskar Morgenstern use a theory of games of strategy to devise a mathematical theory of economic and social organization.

1964 British biologist W.D. Hamilton applies game theory to the evolution of social behavior in animals.

1965 Hamilton uses game theory to describe the ecological consequences of natural selection.

1976 Richard Dawkins popularizes the idea of evolutionarily stable strategies.

AFTER

1982 John Maynard Smith applies the theory to evolution, sexual biology, and life cycles.

The field of behavioral ecology seeks to explain how the behavior of animals—what they eat, how they socialize, and so on—has evolved to suit